

VOCABULARY · CULTURE · ACTIVITIES

DAY OF THE DEAD

El Día de Muertos

The words and the story behind Mexico's most colourful celebration, with Spain 🇪🇸 and Argentina 🇦🇷 vocabulary

PONCHO
SPANISH

¡HOLA!

Every year, at the beginning of November, millions of families in Mexico fill their homes with flowers, candles and photographs to welcome back the people they love and miss.

This resource collects more than 80 words and expressions of el Día de Muertos, each with a real example sentence: the altar at home, the marigolds, the sugar skulls, the food and the stories families tell. At the end you'll find activities to check what you remember, and all the answers.

It is a celebration, not a scary story. Spanish speakers talk about death with warmth and with humour, and learning how they do it teaches you a lot about the language.

How to use it

1. **Read the word, then the sentence.** Words stick better when you see them in action.
2. **Say it out loud.** Mexican names like cempasúchil are fun once you try them.
3. **Look for the symbols:** every flower, candle and photograph on an altar means something.
4. **Try the activities** without looking back, then check the answers.

¿Día de Muertos o Día de los Muertos?

You'll hear both. In Mexico, where the celebration comes from, people mostly say **el Día de Muertos**; outside Mexico **el Día de los Muertos** is very common too. Both are correct, and both mean the same thing.

el Día de Muertos = el Día de los Muertos

Two countries, two words

The tradition is Mexican, so its words are Mexican: **la ofrenda**, **el cempasúchil**, **el pan de muerto**. The everyday words around it do change from country to country: when you see two options, the first is common in Spain 🇪🇸 and the second in Argentina 🇦🇷.

echar de menos 🇪🇸 = **extrañar** 🇦🇷

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01

LA TRADICIÓN

THE TRADITION

What it is, when it happens and who it is for.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el Día de Muertos	the Day of the Dead	*Se celebra el 1 y el 2 de noviembre.* It's celebrated on 1 and 2 November.
la tradición	the tradition	*Es una tradición muy antigua de México.* It's a very old tradition from Mexico.
la costumbre	the custom	*Cada pueblo tiene sus costumbres.* Every town has its own customs.
celebrar	to celebrate	*Celebramos con flores, comida y música.* We celebrate with flowers, food and music.
la fiesta	the celebration	*No es una fiesta triste.* It isn't a sad celebration.
recordar	to remember	*Recordamos a las personas que queremos.* We remember the people we love.
el recuerdo	the memory	*Cada foto es un recuerdo bonito.* Each photo is a lovely memory.
la vida	life	*Es una fiesta que celebra la vida.* It's a celebration of life.
la muerte	death	*Aquí se habla de la muerte con cariño.* Here people talk about death with affection.
los difuntos	the departed	*La ofrenda es para los difuntos.* The altar is for the departed.
el alma	the soul	*Esa noche vuelven las almas.* That night the souls come back.

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01 · LA TRADICIÓN THE TRADITION

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
noviembre	November	*Todo empieza el 31 de octubre.* It all begins on 31 October.
mexicano / mexicana	Mexican	*Es la fiesta mexicana más conocida.* It's the best-known Mexican celebration.
el pueblo	the town, the village	*En el pueblo todos ponen ofrenda.* In the village everyone puts up an altar.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

UNESCO added el Día de Muertos to its list of the intangible cultural heritage of humanity in 2008, as a living tradition that families pass on at home, from grandparents to grandchildren.

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02

LA OFRENDA

THE ALTAR AT HOME

The table families set up at home, and everything that goes on it.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la ofrenda	the altar at home	*Ponemos la ofrenda en el salón.* We put the altar up in the living room.
el altar	the altar	*El altar tiene tres niveles.* The altar has three levels.
poner la ofrenda	to put up the altar	*Ponemos la ofrenda el 30 de octubre.* We put the altar up on 30 October.
la foto	the photograph	*En el centro va la foto de mi bisabuelo.* My great-grandfather's photo goes in the middle.
la vela	the candle	*Encendemos una vela por cada persona.* We light a candle for each person.
la veladora	the candle in a glass	*Las veladoras duran toda la noche.* The candles in glasses last all night.
la cerilla 🇪🇸 el fósforo 🇦🇷	the match	*¿Me pasas una cerilla para la vela?* Can you pass me a match for the candle?
encender	to light	*Mi hermana enciende el incienso.* My sister lights the incense.
el incienso	the incense	*El incienso huele muy fuerte.* The incense has a very strong smell.
el copal	copal (resin incense)	*El copal se quema en un brasero.* Copal is burnt in a small burner.
el papel picado	cut paper bunting	*Colgamos papel picado de colores.* We hang up colourful paper bunting.

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02 · LA OFRENDA THE ALTAR AT HOME

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el vaso de agua	the glass of water	*Se pone un vaso de agua para el viaje.* A glass of water is put out for the journey.
la sal	the salt	*La sal y el agua no pueden faltar.* Salt and water are never missing.
el mantel	the tablecloth	*Mi tía borda el mantel del altar.* My aunt embroiders the altar tablecloth.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Every object on the altar has a job: the water is for a long journey, the salt keeps things pure, the candles are the light that shows the way home, and the paper bunting moves with the air to say that someone has arrived.

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03

LAS FLORES Y LOS COLORES

FLOWERS AND COLOURS

Orange petals everywhere, and the path they make.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la flor	the flower	*La casa se llena de flores.* The house fills up with flowers.
el cempasúchil	the marigold	*Es la flor del Día de Muertos.* It's the flower of the Day of the Dead.
los pétalos	the petals	*Hacemos un camino de pétalos.* We make a path of petals.
el camino	the path	*El camino lleva hasta el altar.* The path leads to the altar.
el campo	the field	*En octubre los campos se ponen naranjas.* In October the fields turn orange.
cortar	to cut, to pick	*Cortamos flores por la mañana temprano.* We pick flowers early in the morning.
el olor	the smell	*El olor del cempasúchil es muy fuerte.* The smell of the marigold is very strong.
oler	to smell	*Toda la casa huele a flores.* The whole house smells of flowers.
el color	the colour	*Es una fiesta llena de color.* It's a celebration full of colour.
naranja	orange	*El naranja es el color de la flor.* Orange is the colour of the flower.
morado	purple	*El morado se usa mucho en el altar.* Purple is used a lot on the altar.

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03 · LAS FLORES Y LOS COLORES FLOWERS AND COLOURS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
amarillo	yellow	*El papel picado amarillo brilla.* The yellow bunting shines.
blanco	white	*Las flores blancas son para los niños.* White flowers are for children.
colorido / colorida	colourful	*¡Qué fiesta tan colorida!* What a colourful celebration!

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Cempasúchil comes from cempohualxóchitl, a word in Nahuatl, the language of the Aztecs, which is still spoken by more than a million people in Mexico today. It means something like 'twenty flowers', because of its many petals.

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04

CALAVERAS Y CATRINAS

SKULLS AND CATRINAS

Smiling skulls, elegant hats and a lot of humour.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la calavera	the skull	*Las calaveras siempre sonríen.* The skulls are always smiling.
la calaverita de azúcar	the little sugar skull	*La calaverita lleva mi nombre.* The sugar skull has my name on it.
el esqueleto	the skeleton	*Los esqueletos bailan y cantan.* The skeletons dance and sing.
la Catrina	the Catrina	*¡Qué elegante es la Catrina!* The Catrina is so elegant!
el sombrero	the hat	*Su sombrero tiene flores y plumas.* Her hat has flowers and feathers on it.
el vestido	the dress	*El vestido verde es mi favorito.* The green dress is my favourite.
las plumas	the feathers	*Las plumas se mueven con el viento.* The feathers move in the wind.
el maquillaje	the face paint	*El maquillaje de calavera es difícil.* Skull face paint is difficult.
pintarse la cara	to paint your face	*Me pinto la cara de calavera.* I paint my face like a skull.
el disfraz	the costume	*Mi disfraz lo hice con ropa vieja.* I made my costume out of old clothes.
el nombre	the name	*El nombre va en la calaverita.* The name goes on the little skull.

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04 · CALAVERAS Y CATRINAS SKULLS AND CATRINAS

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
sonreír	to smile	*Hasta los esqueletos sonríen.* Even the skeletons are smiling.
la sonrisa	the smile	*Me encanta su sonrisa.* I love her smile.
el humor	humour	*Hablan de la muerte con humor.* They talk about death with humour.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

La Catrina was drawn more than a hundred years ago by the Mexican artist José Guadalupe Posada, as a joke about people who were ashamed of where they came from. The painter Diego Rivera gave her the name and the long dress, and today she is the face of the celebration.

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05

LA COMIDA DE LA FIESTA

THE FOOD

What goes on the altar, and what the family eats afterwards.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el pan de muerto	'bread of the dead'	*Sólo se hace en estas fechas.* It's only made at this time of year.
el azúcar	sugar	*Lleva mucha azúcar por encima.* It has lots of sugar on top.
el chocolate caliente	hot chocolate	*Mojamos el pan en chocolate.* We dip the bread in chocolate.
el atole	atole (maize drink)	*Mi abuela prepara atole para todos.* My grandmother makes atole for everyone.
los tamales	tamales	*Se cocinan en hojas de maíz.* They're cooked in maize leaves.
la mazorca 🇪🇸 el choclo 🇦🇷	the corn on the cob	*Compramos mazorcas en el mercado.* We buy corn on the cob at the market.
los frijoles	the beans	*Los tamales de frijoles son ricos.* Bean tamales are delicious.
la calabaza	the pumpkin	*La calabaza lleva canela.* The pumpkin has cinnamon in it.
la fruta	the fruit	*La fruta se come al final.* The fruit is eaten at the end.
el melocotón 🇪🇸 el durazno 🇦🇷	the peach	*Pusimos melocotones y mandarinas.* We put out peaches and tangerines.
la fresa 🇪🇸 la frutilla 🇦🇷	the strawberry	*Le encantaban las fresas.* He loved strawberries.

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05 · LA COMIDA DE LA FIESTA THE FOOD

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
el zumo 🇪🇸 el jugo 🇦🇷	the juice	*Dejamos un vaso de zumo para él.* We leave a glass of juice out for him.
las chucherías 🇪🇸 las golosinas 🇦🇷	the sweets	*Los niños se llevan las chucherías.* The children take the sweets.
compartir	to share	*Después compartimos todo en la mesa.* Afterwards we share everything at the table.

¿SABÍAS QUE...?

Pan de muerto is a round loaf with strips of dough on top that look like bones, and a little ball in the middle. Much of the food of the celebration grows in the ground: maize, beans, pumpkin and fruit, the same crops families have shared for centuries.

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06

LA FAMILIA Y EL RECUERDO

REMEMBERING TOGETHER

The best part of the night: being together and telling stories.

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
la familia	the family	*La familia se junta esa noche.* The family gets together that night.
los abuelos	the grandparents	*Mis abuelos ponen la ofrenda.* My grandparents put up the altar.
los bisabuelos	great-grandparents	*No conocí a mis bisabuelos.* I never met my great-grandparents.
la mascota	the pet	*También recordamos a la perra.* We remember our dog too.
el cementerio	the cemetery	*En México se dice el panteón.* In Mexico people say el panteón.
la tumba	the grave	*Limpiamos la tumba juntos.* We clean the grave together.
visitar	to visit	*Visitamos el cementerio.* We visit the cemetery.
contar	to tell	*Mi madre cuenta historias.* My mum tells stories.
la historia	the story	*Siempre hay una historia nueva.* There's always a new story.
la canción	the song	*Cantamos su canción favorita.* We sing his favourite song.
reír	to laugh	*Nos reímos mucho recordando.* We laugh a lot as we remember.

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06 · LA FAMILIA Y EL RECUERDO

REMEMBERING TOGETHER

ESPAÑOL	ENGLISH	EN UNA FRASE
llorar	to cry	*A veces también lloramos, y está bien.* Sometimes we cry too, and that's fine.
echar de menos 🇪🇸 extrañar 🇦🇷	to miss (someone)	*Te echo de menos todos los días.* I miss you every day.
juntos / juntas	together	*Estamos juntos otra vez.* We're together again.

¿Sabías que...?

In towns like Pátzcuaro and Oaxaca, families spend the whole night at the cemetery with blankets, candles, food and music. For them it isn't a sad place: it's where the family meets up, and children run between the graves.

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07

FRASES DE LA FIESTA

PHRASES FOR THE CELEBRATION

Short sentences you could really say while you help to set up an altar. When there are two versions, the second is how you'd say it in Argentina.

¿Cómo se celebra el Día de Muertos?
How is the Day of the Dead celebrated?

Vamos a poner la ofrenda.
Let's put up the altar.

¿Me ayudas con el papel picado?
Can you help me with the paper bunting?

Esta foto es de mi abuela.
This photo is of my grandmother.

Voy a encender una vela.
I'm going to light a candle.

Huele a cempasúchil.
It smells of marigolds.

Me encanta el pan de muerto.
I love pan de muerto.

¿Quieres un poco de chocolate caliente?
Would you like some hot chocolate?

Cuéntame una historia de él.
Tell me a story about him.

Te echo de menos. / Te extraño.
I miss you.

Siempre te recuerdo.
I always remember you.

¡Qué bonito quedó el altar! / ¡Qué lindo quedó el altar!
The altar looks lovely!

¿Sabías que...?

You don't wish someone a 'happy' Day of the Dead in the way you'd say happy birthday. People say feliz Día de Muertos, but the warmest thing you can say to a friend is ¿a quién vas a recordar este año? — who are you going to remember this year?

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08

¡A RECORDAR!

ACTIVITIES

1 MATCH THEM UP

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish word or phrase.

1	la ofrenda	☐	A	the marigold
2	el cempasúchil	☐	B	'bread of the dead'
3	la vela	☐	C	the petals
4	el papel picado	☐	D	the altar at home
5	la calavera	☐	E	to share
6	el pan de muerto	☐	F	the skull
7	los pétalos	☐	G	the memory
8	el recuerdo	☐	H	the candle
9	la tumba	☐	I	the grave
10	compartir	☐	J	cut paper bunting

2 ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

Read each sentence and circle V (true) or F (false).

1. El Día de Muertos se celebra el 1 y el 2 de noviembre. **V** **F**
2. El cempasúchil es un animal. **V** **F**
3. El papel picado se cuelga para decorar la casa. **V** **F**
4. El pan de muerto es un tipo de sopa. **V** **F**
5. En la ofrenda se ponen fotos de la familia. **V** **F**
6. Las calaveras del Día de Muertos son tristes y dan miedo. **V** **F**

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3 UNA CARTA DESDE OAXACA

Complete Lucía's letter with the words from the box.

noviembre · ofrenda · fotos · velas · cempasúchil · pan · historias · recuerdo

¡Hola! Te escribo desde Oaxaca. El 2 de _____ pusimos la _____ en casa de mi abuela. Encima hay _____ de mis bisabuelos y muchas _____ encendidas. Hicimos un camino de pétalos de _____ desde la puerta hasta el altar. Mi tía trajo _____ de muerto y chocolate caliente. Por la noche contamos _____ y nos reímos mucho. No es una fiesta triste: es un _____ muy bonito.

4 SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

Write the word used in Argentina next to the one used in Spain.

- **echar de menos** → _____
- **las chucherías** → _____
- **la cerilla** → _____
- **el melocotón** → _____
- **el zumo** → _____
- **la fresa** → _____
- **la mazorca** → _____
- **bonito** → _____

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5 SOPA DE LETRAS

Find the 12 words. They go across → or down ↓.

O	T	V	E	L	A	M	V	U	L	E	S
O	V	B	P	T	N	N	N	N	D	R	N
F	M	B	C	A	L	A	V	E	R	A	G
R	U	C	F	A	M	I	L	I	A	G	P
E	E	A	L	T	A	R	F	D	L	V	B
N	R	D	A	A	Z	U	C	A	R	P	U
D	T	E	T	P	A	P	E	L	D	E	M
A	O	F	L	O	R	E	S	V	A	T	C
G	S	V	C	A	T	R	I	N	A	A	N
R	E	C	U	E	R	D	O	E	I	L	M
V	M	R	D	D	R	P	R	R	J	O	C
E	D	L	I	R	F	S	A	G	S	S	M

OFRENDA
CALAVERA
CATRINA
VELA
FLORES
PETALOS
ALTAR
MUERTOS
FAMILIA
AZUCAR
RECUERDO
PAPEL

6 PUT IT IN ORDER

Unscramble each sentence and write it on the line.

1. **poner / Vamos / a / ofrenda / la**

_____

2. **muerto / Mi / prepara / pan / de / abuela**

_____

3. **encendidas / están / velas / Las**

_____

4. **te / recuerdo / Siempre**

_____

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7 TU OFRENDA

Imagine you are making an ofrenda. Think of someone, or even a pet, you'd like to remember, and write four or five sentences: who they are, what you would put on the altar for them and why. Use at least six words from this resource.

Try: En mi ofrenda pongo... Esta foto es de... Le gustaba... Siempre recuerdo cuando...

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ANSWERS

1 · MATCH THEM UP

1–D, 2–A, 3–H, 4–J, 5–F, 6–B, 7–C, 8–G, 9–I, 10–E

2 · ¿VERDADERO O FALSO?

1 V, 2 F, 3 V, 4 F, 5 V, 6 F

3 · UNA CARTA DESDE OAXACA

1. noviembre, 2. ofrenda, 3. fotos, 4. velas, 5. cempasúchil, 6. pan, 7. historias, 8. recuerdo

4 · SPAIN OR ARGENTINA?

echar de menos → extrañar; la cerilla → el fósforo; el zumo → el jugo; la mazorca → el choclo; las chucherías → las golosinas; el melocotón → el durazno; la fresa → la frutilla; bonito → lindo

6 · PUT IT IN ORDER

Vamos a poner la ofrenda. · Mi abuela prepara pan de muerto. · Las velas están encendidas. · Siempre te recuerdo.

7 · TU OFRENDA

Any answer that uses six words from this resource is perfect. Read it out loud at home: the stories are the best part of the celebration.

5 · SOPA DE LETRAS

O	T	V	E	L	A	M	V	U	L	E	S
O	V	B	P	T	N	N	N	N	D	R	N
F	M	B	C	A	L	A	V	E	R	A	G
R	U	C	F	A	M	I	L	I	A	G	P
E	E	A	L	T	A	R	F	D	L	V	B
N	R	D	A	A	Z	U	C	A	R	P	U
D	T	E	T	P	A	P	E	L	D	E	M
A	O	F	L	O	R	E	S	V	A	T	C
G	S	V	C	A	T	R	I	N	A	A	N
R	E	C	U	E	R	D	O	E	I	L	M
V	M	R	D	D	R	P	R	R	J	O	C
E	D	L	I	R	F	S	A	G	S	S	M

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¡FELIZ DÍA DE MUERTOS!

SEE YOU SOON

Now you know the words, the flowers and the stories. This November, light a candle for someone you miss and say their name out loud: that's the whole tradition, in one small gesture.

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